

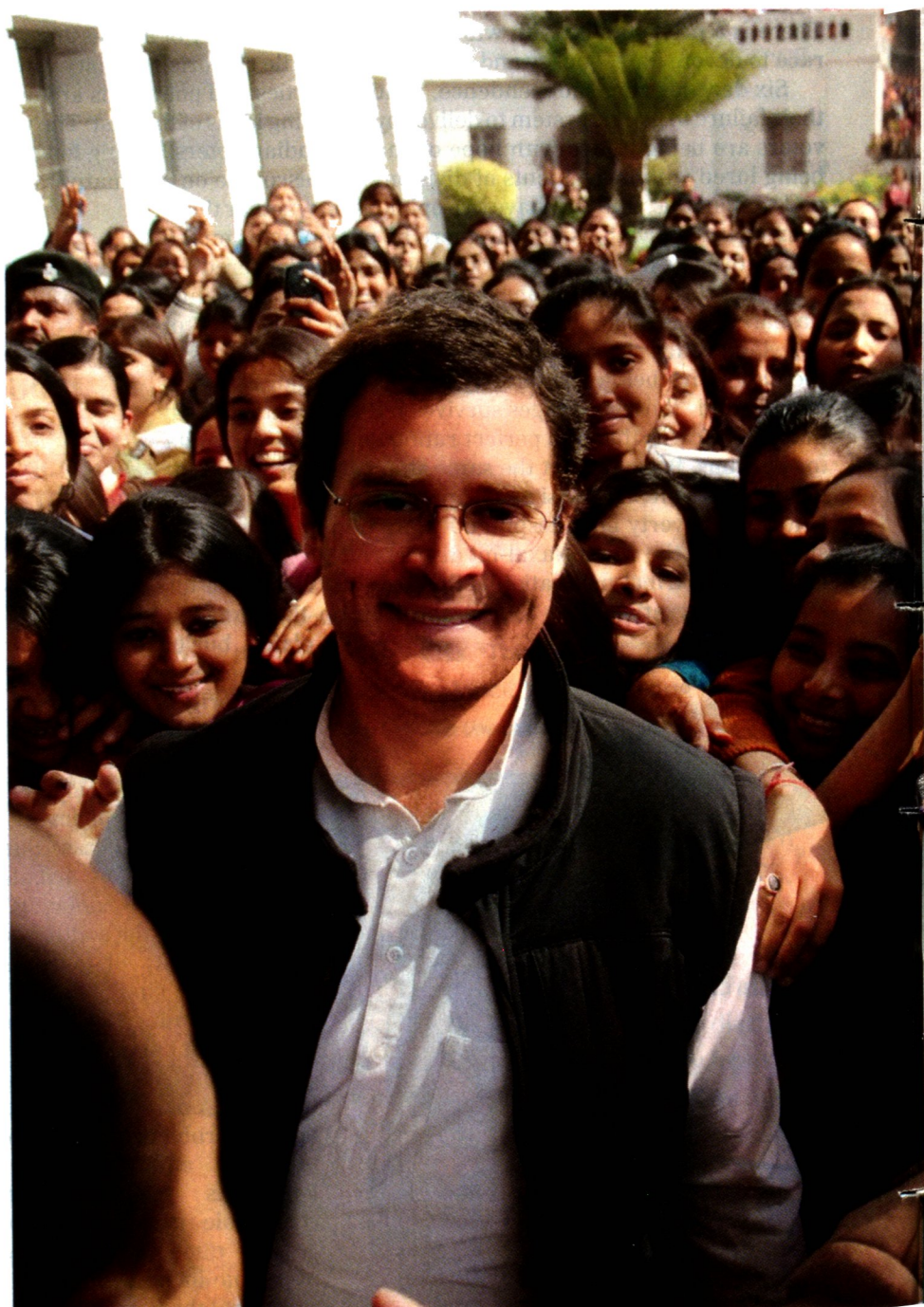
The Power OF ONE

Replacing nominations with elections and patronage with merit, Rahul Gandhi has singlehandedly scripted the Youth Congress' most successful turnaround story

By Priya Sahgal

When Rahul Gandhi, a fourth generation dynast, talked about bringing in democracy to the Indian Youth Congress (IYC), few took him seriously. After all that was an organisation where nominations instead of elections, and patronage not merit, were the norm. Yet in an era where change is the buzzword, the 39-year-old scion took charge of the party's youth wings and turned them into laboratories for his experiments with democracy. It has taken him nearly three years to prove that he can be the change he talks about.

First he launched an aggressive and ambitious membership drive, reaching out to the young and restless with a simple message: "We have millions of Barack Obamas sitting here in India. It's a question of channelling them, moving them into the political system and giving them power." The power that Rahul was offering was an invitation to join the IYC and the National Students' Union of India, a chance to take part in what he calls an "open and transparent" election process. Earlier anyone who wanted to join the Youth Congress had to be sponsored by an existing member. Those who recruited 25 people became active members and eligible to contest the polls. But that was then. Now all it takes to be part of Rahul's team is an easily accessible online nomination form with no signature other than the candidate's. A relieved



CAMPUSES ARE VITAL STOPOVERS IN RAHUL'S RECRUITMENT DRIVE

KRISHNA MURARI KISHAN